

artworks that reflect on the themes of migration, labour and aspiration. Aspiration, in particular, is ingrained in the exhibition's title. It's also evident in 'School' (2008), where rows of thalis in front of low stools depict the ritual of a community meal. The stools gleam golden, but are in fact brass ones, cast from a stool that belonged to Gupta's father. "I grew up sitting on this stool. The idea of casting it in a shiny material like brass was to give it the appearance of gold and elevate its prestige," says Gupta.

> Gupta has reimagined common objects **into artworks that reflect on** themes of migration, labour and aspiration

Several works are being shown in India for the first time. For instance, 'Proust Mapping' (2024-26), which stretches over nine metres and is made from flattened cooking vessels marked by years of use. From afar, the surface appears abstract; up close, dents, scratches and burn marks reveal traces of everyday labour. Gupta takes a close-up photo of one of the flattened vessels, and it resembles the cosmos, again hinting at something larger than what meets the eye. The eponymous centrepiece of the exhibition is a new installation on the second floor. Wooden bedframes—each with a mattress shrouded in a polyester mosquito net—stand like museum vitrines, showcasing diverse scenes that draw on ideas of rest, migration and memory. A terracotta-tiled roof in one, a stack of cow-dung cakes in another, and yet another with tightly bundled luggage and belongings—a familiar scene across railway stations in India. Also familiar is a dripping tap surrounded by a jumble of steel buckets, a commentary on the next (possible) resource war.

On the third floor is the monumental 'Kingdom of Earth' (2016-26), where 7.5-metre-tall pillars topped off with capitals remind one of ancient Greek and Roman ruins. Next to it, sculptural fragments recall other archaeological remains, including animal bones. Some of the columns are made of steel bowls, glasses and tins, all stacked together tightly. "In my work, I often begin with familiar, everyday objects, but when they shift in scale, their meaning also changes," says Gupta. "What is usually small and unnoticed becomes something you have to physically experience. This shift allows the viewer to engage more directly with the object and what it carries."

The exhibition culminates on the fourth floor with 'Faith Matters' (2007–10). Shown in India for the first time, it comprises sets of stainless steel utensils and tiffins moving along conveyor belts, echoing the everyday cycles of cooking, labour and exchange. "Even in a fast-changing city like Mumbai, I feel that the core of our daily lives doesn't really change," says Gupta. "Our routines may become faster, more fragmented, or more modern, but the basic human experiences like family, sharing food and being with others remain the same. That's why I feel my work can exist anywhere—in a small town or a big city—and still connect with people." ■

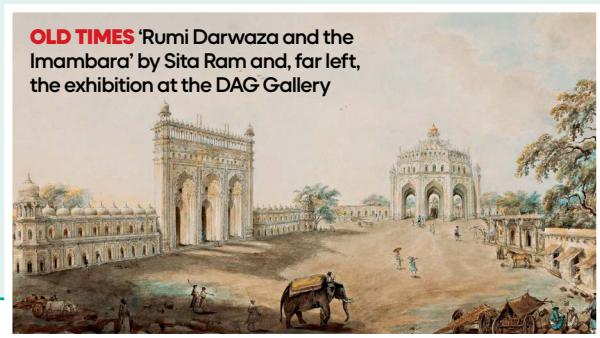
—Prachi Joshi

Subodh Gupta's A Fistful of Sky *is on view at NMACC until May 17; tickets from Rs 250*

thetics and the politics of the picturesque are the focus of an exhibition at Delhi's DAG—*The Indian Picturesque: Landscape Painting 1800-1850*. Curated by Giles Tillotson, it brings together British and Indian landscape paintings from the first half of the 19th century.

Viewed side by side, these paintings show a wide array of artistic and sociological connections, an artistic dialogue between the English and the Indian. They also betray the ideological project that lay at the heart of the picturesque. For instance, many paintings here show buildings in ruins—like 'Front View of the Ruined Mosque, the Jumah Musjid' (1852) by Claudius Richard William Harris or 'Remains of an Ancient Building near Firoz Shah's Cotilla', Delhi (1850) by an unnamed artist. As Tillotson explains in the exhibition book, drawing abandoned, hollowed-out buildings showcased the empire's control and dominion over the land.

Among the Indian artists on display is Sita Ram, a major artist of the Company School. His 'Rumi Darwaza and Entrance to the Imambara at Lucknow' (1815-25) is an example of an Indian artist blending English landscape methods with Indian techniques. *The Indian Picturesque* is highly recommended for art and history buffs. ■



OLD TIMES 'Rumi Darwaza and the Imambara' by Sita Ram and, far left, the exhibition at the DAG Gallery

—Aditya Mani Jha

The exhibition is on view till May 2